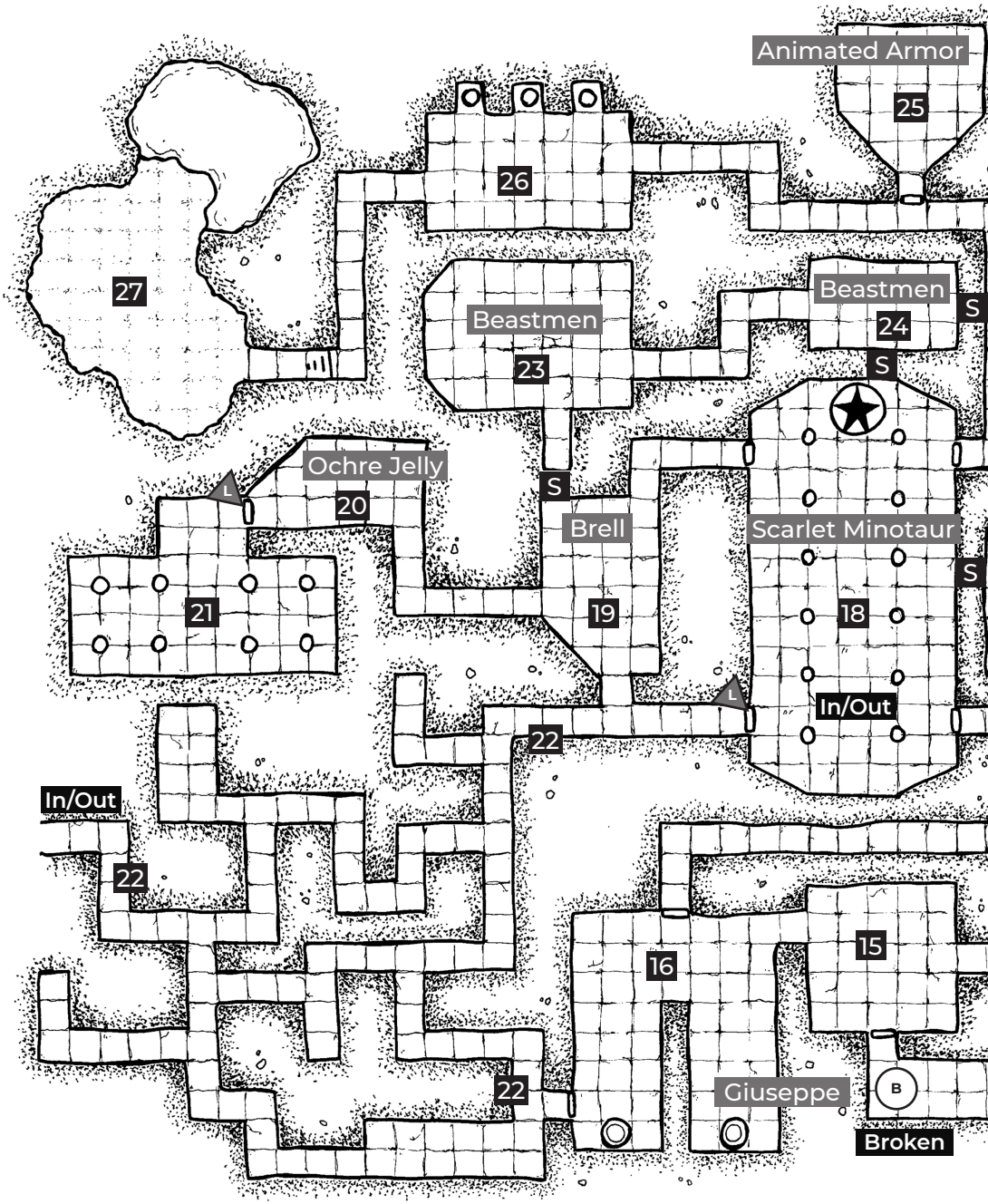
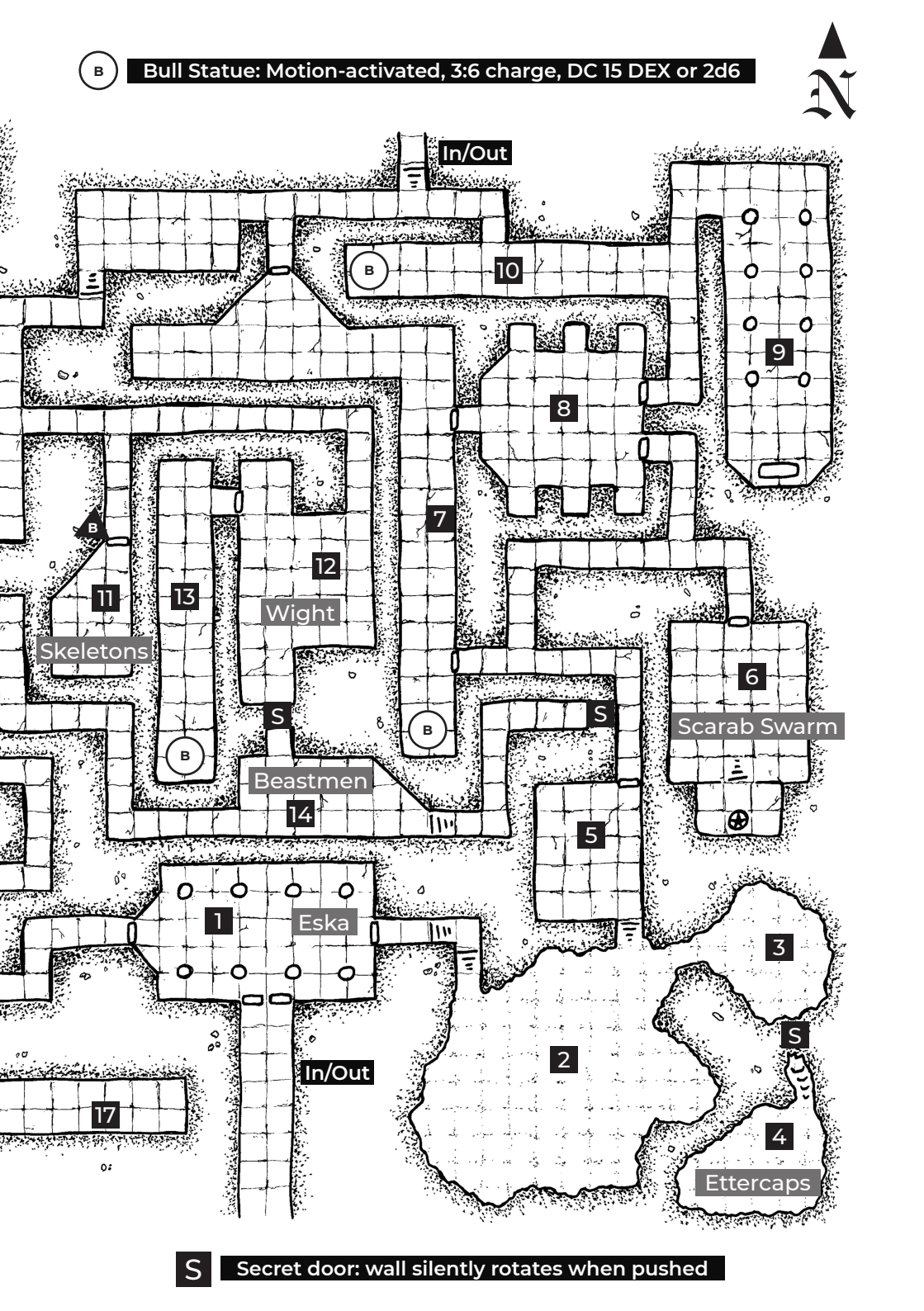
The Lost Citadel



L Locked: DC 20 DEX pick, DC 18 STR force

B Barricaded: DC 18 STR


B
Bull Statue: Motion-activated, 3:6 charge, DC 15 DEX or 2d6
N
In/Out
10
9
8
7
12
11
13
Wight
Skeletons
6
Scarab Swarm
S
Beastmen
14
5
1
Eska
3
S
2
In/Out
17
4
Ettercaps
S
Secret door: wall silently rotates when pushed

Lost Citadel of the Scarlet Minotaur

A 1st-3rd-level adventure for Shadowdark RPG

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ShadowDark

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Foreword

The Lost Citadel awaits those brave enough to face it!

Lost Citadel of the Scarlet Minotaur is the starter adventure for *Shadowdark RPG*, and it has introduced many a crawler to the art of dungeon survival.

When I wrote this module, I had two goals in mind.

First, it was to show new Shadowdark players the various challenges they would face in this game.

Second, it was to teach them how to crawl.

In this dungeon, players will swiftly learn that the Scarlet Minotaur is not a foe their PCs should face head-on in a "fair fight."

They will get used to checking their torches.

They will learn to spot the signs of a charging bull trap around the corner.

Through this, the players learn how to dungeon crawl.

They'll discover the joys of old-school gaming where their choices are the key to survival, not game balance or encounters designed with pre-set solutions.

Consider Area 9: Sorcerous Pillars. There is no solution to this puzzle; I've never had two groups defeat the pillars in the exact same way. The pillars demand experimentation, risk, and creativity to overcome.

PC deaths will happen. But do not mourn the fallen.

Let their lessons serve as the next torch lighting the way!

-Kelsey Dionne, July 2026

Sly Flourish's Tips

Lost Citadel of the Scarlet Minotaur offers a fantastic opportunity for GMs and players to learn more about *Shadowdark RPG* and enjoy an adventure as their characters delve into ancient ruins and seek powerful artifacts.

It's also a fantastic adventure to run at conventions, local game shops, or anytime you want to run a quick game for friends.

The *Quickstart Set* is a perfect package for such games. It's lightweight, portable, and includes everything you need. It's my favorite package to run at conventions.

Mix the *Quickstart Set* with some pre-generated PCs (bring about two per player in case of... well, you know), some dice, index cards, pencils, minis or tokens to represent PCs and monsters, maybe a wet- or dry-erase mat, and some markers, and you've got a fantastic kit for your GM go-bag.

RUNNING IT AS A ONE-SHOT

As written, *Scarlet Minotaur* can fill one or more sessions of play. The existing format might be perfect for home groups who want to enjoy a longer adventure over several sessions, but it might not work as well for games where time is limited, such as games at conventions, local game shops, or single-session games at home where time is a factor.

But fear not! With some slight modifications, you can run *Scarlet Minotaur* as a timed single-session game focused on the heroes recovering three items of power before they face the dreaded Scarlet Minotaur.

Here's a breakdown for running *Scarlet Minotaur* as a timed single-session game:

1. The characters arrive at the hillside where lies the Lost Citadel of the Scarlet Minotaur.

2. The characters have a set amount of time to recover as many of the existing three weapons of power as they can.

When the time runs out, any torches go out and the Scarlet Minotaur approaches.

3. The three weapons include:

- The *+1 greatsword Asterion* found in area 9.
- The *+1 spear Vigilant* found in area 21.
- The *+1 greataxe Bloodlust* held by the Scarlet Minotaur himself.

4. The GM clarifies the goal to the players, clarifies the time limit, and hints at the dangers they face should time run out.

5. The characters can choose their entrance and choose their approach.

You may want to state that the Citadel itself is going to collapse by the session's end so the players don't feel like they should continue exploring further if they manage to slay the Scarlet Minotaur.

But you could also skip this collapse setup since the victory over the Scarlet Minotaur is usually enough to make for a fine conclusion to the game!

Feel free to narrate that the characters recover any final weapons they might not have retrieved at the end of the session.

A HEROIC BEGINNING

The goal of acquiring powerful weapons in the Lost Citadel might not be enough to motivate players to risk the lives of their PCs in such a dastardly place. If you want a stronger motivation, consider the following:

The PCs come from the nearby village of **Stoval**. Bandits began harassing the townsfolk, and their attacks have become more frequent and more violent. The village doesn't have the resources to defend itself, but a band of heroes armed with the legendary weapons found in the Lost Citadel could help the village fight off the bandits and keep the village safe.

The village elders sent forth their heroes — the PCs — to enter the Lost Citadel, find the three weapons of power, and return with them to defend the village from the marauding bandits.

This intro gives the players a stronger motivation for entering the Lost Citadel and staying there, even if death lies around every corner (and it sure might).

Clarify that the characters need not recover *all* the weapons to succeed in their quest. They can still fend off the bandits, although with more difficulty, if they have only one or two of the weapons. This caveat helps ensure players don't feel too much pressure to get all three items and feel like they failed if they escape with only two.

PLAYING ON A TIMER

A timed version of *Lost Citadel of the Scarlet Minotaur* fits comfortably within **four hours**, but you can run it with as little as three. The main difference is when you decide to turn off the lights and have the Scarlet Minotaur start hunting the PCs.

Usually it works best to trigger the Minotaur's arrival 30 minutes before the end of the session.

That gives the players enough time to beat feet out of the Citadel or face the Minotaur and accept their fate.

It's very possible for the characters to kill the Scarlet Minotaur (in fact, you wouldn't be breaking my heart if you beefed up his hit points a little bit to make him an even greater threat), and you don't want to rob the players of their victory by cutting the time short.

If you want to leave some extra room, 45 minutes before the end of the session can work as well.

Ensure you set a timer or alarm for the Minotaur's arrival and keep that alarm separate from your torch timers. Let your players know you'll be having a break somewhere in the middle of the session so they're aware that any plans they have are going to be about 10 minutes behind. You don't want to rush the players too much and breaks are important.

When the time runs out, all light is expended and the Minotaur arrives!

Roll a d6 to see how close the Minotaur is to the characters using the distance chart in the front inside cover of the *Game Master Quickstart Guide*.

"Far" means the Scarlet Minotaur is a room or two away while "close" means he's right around the corner. Describe how the PCs' torches suddenly snuff out and they hear the heavy breathing and footstomps of the Minotaur coming, only a slight gleam appearing on the razor-sharp edge of the Minotaur's axe, *Bloodlust*.

Then run the final encounter and enjoy the outcome!

When rolling for random encounters, a roll of 1 indicates that the Scarlet Minotaur arrives. Arriving early could cause a couple of potential undesirable situations: the characters could kill the Minotaur early and thus throw off the rest of the timing of the session, or the characters could get wiped out.

It's possible after wounding the Minotaur that it returns to its central lair in Area 18 to recover. You might decide that the Minotaur encounter either reveals signs of his passage or that it could be *another* minotaur without the axe. Why might he not be the only one?

If you decide to modify the random encounter table this way, ignore the -2 result that steers the random encounters towards an encounter with the Minotaur.

TIPS AND TRICKS FOR RUNNING IT

Here are some other tips and tricks to make the most of this adventure.

First, ensure the players know that there could be multiple entrances to the Citadel.

It's more fun when the PCs explore the hill and decide on their approach, making every session unique. If you don't give them hints up front, the players are likely to just enter the first entrance they see.

Second, the ettercaps in Areas 1-4 and in random encounters can be surprisingly dangerous, particularly in large numbers.

Instead of playing them hostile, consider having them behave as more shifty and troublesome. They might steer the characters the wrong direction or try to use the characters to their advantage in their struggle against the beastmen.

If the PCs choose violence, that's up to them, but otherwise, consider roleplaying the ettercaps as more mischievous than violent and save yourself the quick potential TPK.

SLY FLOURISH'S HOUSE RULES

Shadowdark and *Lost Citadel of the Scarlet Minotaur* run great as-is, but I'll offer you a handful of house rules I use when running them at conventions:

1. The PCs begin with a single luck token. New PCs likewise begin with a luck token. PCs are unlikely to gain a new luck token during the game itself.

2. PCs don't lose access to a spell on a failed spellcasting check until they successfully cast it at least once. Thus, spellcasters get at least one use of a spell before they potentially lose it.

3. Torches last 60 - 1d12 minutes (rolled by the GM in secret) to add variance to torch timers. The GM keeps track of torch timers. Players are allowed to look at a clock, but players setting a timer is considered bad form.

4. PCs cannot be stabilized at 0 HP. PCs either have 1 hit point or they're dying. Stabilizing someone can bring a PC back to 1 hit point if they roll a 20, but otherwise, PCs at 0 HP are dying. This prevents the "Weekend at Bernies" problem where an unconscious PC is being dragged through the dungeon while the player can't do anything.

5. When a PC begins their turn at 0 HP, the GM rolls 1d4 **in secret** for the number of rounds the PC has until they die. If a PC with 0 HP takes any damage, the number of rounds they have left decreases by 1.

6. A creature can kill a PC who is at 0 HP with a single deliberate attack and have advantage on the attack.

7. The players of dead PCs select new characters to rejoin the party after combat is over. This prevents players from cycling in a whole bunch of PCs when a TPK is the likely outcome.

You're free to choose any of these house rules (or none of them) as you see fit.

YOUR QUICK INTRO TO SHADOWDARK

Lost Citadel of the Scarlet Minotaur, combined with the *Shadowdark Quickstart Set* rules and the scenario description above, gives you a fun, fast, and high-energy introduction to Shadowdark.

It's perfect for convention play or a quick night of dungeon delving with your friends around the table.

Keep those torches lit and keep your eyes keen. The Scarlet Minotaur approaches.

Mike Shea, *also known as Sly Flourish, is the author of* **Rise of the Lazy Game Master**, *as well as many other fantastic books. Visit his site at slyflourish.com!*

Mark
YONS

Surviving The Citadel

You're asking me about the Lost Citadel, traveler? May the divine light of Saint Terragnis keep you.

Yes. I know that accursed place.

I know it because I was a braver man, once. Freshly ordained at the temple, the holy prayers of the goddess still new on my lips.

I learned about the Citadel from someone much like how you see me now. A man with haunted eyes and a half-moon scar across his chest that never truly mends.

I didn't listen to this man. He told me of the Citadel's darkness, and I told him of the magical light I could summon. He warned me about the beast-men who crept and clawed and betrayed, and I assured him I was no easy mark.

Soon enough, I met the stalwart adventurers who became my companions-in-arms. We loaded our packs and set out for the mythical Citadel. Glory would be ours to take, we knew.

Ha! What noble fools we were!

Inside those cold, towering halls, we learned the cost of hubris.

The darkness inside there is not... ordinary. It isn't the quiet dark of a moonless night. It is absolute. It seeps into your mind. It chokes the feeble torch you hold, and causes your tongue to stumble when you pray for magical light.

And the Minotaur. The Red Devil. The last thing my companions saw on this earth. By the grace of the goddess, I awoke among their bodies, barely alive... and never to return. Never again.

SHARED WISDOM

d4	In The Citadel, You...
1	Find an extra torch in your backpack (once)
2	Get +1 on your death timer
3	Gain ADV on a DEX check of your choice (once)
4	Regain 1 lost spell or 1d6 HP (once)

Overview

ROOM KEY

The keyworded **descriptions** at the start of each location are safe to share with the players. The **bulleted details** beneath are for the GM.

BACKGROUND

Long ago, a mighty enclave of warriors lived inside the Lost Citadel. They worshipped bulls in ever-bloodier, cultish rituals that culminated in their leader, Minoros, transforming into the **Scarlet Minotaur**. This immortal avatar of rage slaughtered the warriors in a single night of mayhem. However, some of their servants escaped through the unseen halls used by the lowly. These **beastmen** hid in the fallen citadel, trapped by superstitious fear of the outside.

FACTIONS

Beastmen. These gray-furred, feral beings have evaded the Scarlet Minotaur for generations. They dwell in Area 23, believing dragons wait outside to devour anyone who leaves the citadel. Endless fear has made them vicious and craven. Their leader, Rogath, rules by the might of his claws.

Ettercaps. Recently, a group of ettercaps crept into Area 4 from the caves below the citadel. They slink through the Minotaur-haunted halls, tempted by forgotten gems and gold. They plan to depart "as soon as we have enough loot," a moment which never seems to arrive. They are leaderless and unanimously greedy.

The Scarlet Minotaur. Towering, blood-red, snorting and frothing. It plows through the labyrinthine halls of the Lost Citadel looking for creatures to slay. The Minotaur returns to Area 18 between patrols.

RUMORS

1	Ancient kings who dwelt in the citadel possessed magical weapons that were feared far and wide.
2	A savage minotaur drenched in blood stalks the citadel's halls.
3	Piles of gems and gold lie about as if totally forgotten.
4	Beware when touching the body of a dead citadel dweller.
5	Opportunistic, gray-furred beastmen haunt the shadows.
6	The citadel is rife with secret rooms and passageways.

THE LOST CITADEL ENVIRONS & ENTRANCES

The Citadel. Cicadas buzz in the arid scrubland around the citadel. Thick, sandy blocks and coral-red columns hold up its tiered rooftops (30'-40' high, flat). The enclosed interior is a cool, dark maze of vaulted chambers and halls that funnel into a central courtyard.

- **Southeast Doors.** To Area 1. Carved with bucking bulls, mid-leap.
- **Northeast Hall.** Shattered door lies before stairwell to Area 10.
- **Southwest Hall.** Open tunnel, leads into the labyrinth, Area 22.
- **Courtyard.** Area 18, open-air. Rooftop climbers can reach it.

ORDER OF BATTLE

Beastmen. Retreat toward Area 14 or Area 23, avoiding Area 18. Know location of all secret doors. Lead enemies into bull statue traps. Will not leave hiding to help others. Terrified of making noise.

Ettercaps. Creep along the ceiling, avoiding bull statues. Unaware of secret doors. Retreat toward Area 4 and gang up to assist allies. Distracted by treasure. Reluctant to enter Area 18.

The Scarlet Minotaur. Pursues its quarry and never retreats. Unaware of secret doors. Forgets about unseen foes in 1d6 rounds. Returns to Area 18 at least once an hour.

Areas 1-27

Danger Level. Risky. Check for an encounter every **2** crawling rounds or after the PCs make loud noises (1d6, 1 = encounter).

Light. Total darkness unless noted. All denizens are dark-adapted.

Doors. Stone. 1:6 chance of being stuck shut. Unlocked unless noted.

NPCs. See pg. 30 for beastmen and ettercap NPC generators.

The Scarlet Minotaur. Each time you roll on the Random Encounters table after the first, apply a **cumulative -2** to the result (treat results below 1 as 1). Reset this count each time an encounter with the Scarlet Minotaur occurs.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

d8	Details
1	The **Scarlet Minotaur** (Area 18) stalks into sight, bellowing challenges and pawing the stone
2	1d4 **ettercaps** and 1d8 **beastmen** clash in a bloody melee
3	A dry gust of wind extinguishes all torches and lamps
4	1d6 **ettercaps** creep along, searching for gold and gems
5	The **skeletons** of 1d6 dead adventurers or warrior-mages stagger into sight
6	2d4 **beastmen** argue in hushed whispers over who gets to eat the centipedes they just trapped in a bag
7	1d4 **darkmantles** swoop out, bobbing and spinning in a territorial warning dance
8	A **cave creeper** rushes along the ceiling toward light

1. MURAL CHAMBER

Walls: Floor-to-ceiling murals painted in vibrant jewel tones. **Red Pillars:** Tapered, banded in black marble at top and bottom.

- **Murals.** People in white robes kneeling in a room of red pillars before a colossal, onyx bull with horns lowered.
  - ▸ **Hidden Niche.** Behind onyx bull mural. Silver bull horn (30 gp).
- **Ettercap NPC. Eska** (weaselly, disloyal). Just hid a stolen pearl in Area 2. Hides on the northeast corner of ceiling. Screeches an alarm and flees toward Area 4 if attacked.
  - ▸ **Escapes.** Three ettercaps from Area 4 set an **ambush** in Area 2.

2. BLINDING CAVE

Walls: Flecked with countless, smooth shards of quartz. **White Bundles:** Man-sized, several stuffed into cave corners.

- **Ettercap Ambush.** If Eska in Area 1 raised alarm, three hostile ettercaps from Area 4 cling to 20' ceiling.
- **Walls.** Dazzlingly reflective. DC 12 DEX when entering with bright light or blinded for 1d4 rounds (ettercaps are unaffected).
  - ▸ **Prying.** Carefully extracted piece of cave wall serves as a mirror.
- **White Bundles.** Five **beastmen** wrapped in ettercap silk. 1:6 chance one still lives. Pearl (40 gp) hidden inside one's mouth.

3. WEB-CHOKED CAVE

Walls and Floor: Covered in thick, gauzy sheets of webbing.

- **Webs.** Sticky. DC 12 STR to break free and move each turn. Highly flammable (1d6 damage to stuck creatures, burns 1d4 rounds).
  - ▸ **Rolled Parchment.** Stuck in webs, 10' up. *Scroll of Hold Portal*.
- **Secret Tunnel.** Hidden by a wall of webs. Ettercaps reseal it each time they pass through.
  - ▸ **Chittering.** Listeners hear shrill, tittering whispers from Area 4.

4. ETTERCAP NEST

Creatures: Group of purple-furred, potbellied humanoids with spindly legs. Snarling at each other about a missing pearl. **Cave:** Cramped, tufts of spiderweb everywhere. **Floor:** Neat piles of gold and lustrous objects. **Ceiling:** Low (10'), three narrow shafts (1').

- **Ettercaps.** Five. Three go to Area 2 if **Eska** (Area 1) raises an alarm. Might parlay, but are fatally treasure-crazed. Squeeze through ceiling shafts with scoops of each other's loot if outclassed.
  - ▸ **NPCs. Skir** (animated, loud), **Yisha** (tiny, sinister), **Grisk** (old, irritable), **Uliss** (lumbering, dull), **Chee** (silver fur, elegant).
- **Treasure.** 12 evenly-valued piles (some belong to wanderers). **Eska** (Area 1) stole a pearl from Grisk's share and hid it in Area 2.
  - ▸ **Details.** 200 gp, 2 pearls (40 gp each), alabaster statuette of a bull (20 gp), 2 silver incense bowls (15 gp each), jade snake bracelet (20 gp), necklace of thick gold links (30 gp).

5. ROBING CHAMBER

Skeleton: Pinned to wall. Hands clasp a spear jutting from ribcage. **Walls:** Chipped mosaic of cavorting dolphins. White robes on pegs.

- **Skeleton.** Wears decaying, crimson-dyed leather armor. Bronze shortsword hangs from belt.
  - ▸ **Spear.** Driven deep into stone with inhuman force. Bronze tip.
- **Robes.** Four. Musty, rotten. Bronze **key** to Area 21 in one's pocket.

6. BATHHOUSE

Statue: A life-sized, snake-haired woman with arms raised and mouth open in a scream. **Stone Basins:** Smooth, human-sized.

- **Statue.** Turning the hinged arms down causes scalding water to spew from mouth (DC 12 DEX to leap aside or 1d4 damage).
- **Basins.** Six. Coiling snake carvings. Stone plugs wedged in drains.
  - ▸ **Removing Plugs.** Cumulative 1:6 to unleash a **scarab swarm**.

7. BULL STATUE

Bull Statue: Towering (10'), bronze. Horns lowered for a charge. **Hall:** 15' high. Pairs of deep holes punched into wall opposite statue.

- **Statue.** Motion-activated. 3:6 chance/round it animates and charges to end of hall (ignores Scarlet Minotaur). DC 15 DEX or 2d6 damage and knocked flat. Trots back to position and resets.
  - ▸ **Emerald.** 120 gp, embedded in statue's forehead. Shattering (AC 20, 1 HP) deactivates statue but reduces gem's value to 20 gp.

8. BLOOD BOWLS

Alcoves: Square, black plinths each hold a simple terracotta bowl.

- ***Blood Bowls*.** Six. Stamped with a seal that shows a warrior kneeling in a black rain, arms and mouth open to the sky.
  - ▸ **Use.** Filling a bowl with fresh blood charges the blood with healing magic (1d4 HP, must drink). Once used, bowl crumbles.

9. SORCEROUS PILLARS

Pillars: Four pairs, painted rich jewel tones. Capped in black marble. **Body:** Purple, spindly humanoid lies facedown halfway across room. **Greatsword:** Bronze, brightly polished. Blade is sunken into a black marble altar beyond the pillars.

- **Pillars.** Moving past each pair activates their effect. Returning past the pair ends it. In order, from north to south:
  - ▸ **Red.** Anything flammable on you ignites. 1d4 damage/round.
  - ▸ **Blue.** Sea water fills your lungs. You drown in 1d6 rounds.
  - ▸ **Green.** Poisoned. DC 12 CON on your turn or lose turn.
  - ▸ **Purple.** You go blind and move at half speed.
- **Body.** Ettercap. Scorched fur. Mouth and chest matted with salt rime. Claw marks around eyes.
- **Greatsword.** DC 12 STR to remove from altar. *+1 greatsword* called *Asterion*. A creature cannot move the wielder against their will.

10. BULL STATUE

- **Bull Statue.** As Area 7. Skeleton stuck on horns covers emerald.

11. PRISON

Door: Hefty stone slab with keyhole. Cold and damp to the touch.

- **Door.** Unlocked, barricaded from inside. DC 18 STR to force.
  - ▸ **Listening.** Faint metallic, clinking sound on other side.
  - ▸ **Keyhole.** Darkness with a few points of bobbing, red light.
- **Inside.** Four **skeletons** in tattered, red leather armor shuffle around, knocking into manacles anchored to floor. Four bronze-shod **spears** braced through handle (broken if door opened).
  - ▸ **Walls.** Scratched in ancient Common: "Days since the Beast appeared." About 40 tally lines below it, gradually fainter.

12. ARMORY

Floor: Tangled heaps of gaping skeletons. **Walls:** A bronze dagger sticks in the stone by its point. **Alcoves:** Splintered, wooden racks.

- **Skeletons.** Twelve. Several are cut completely in half. Tatters of red-dyed armor, shattered shields, and bronze shortswords.
  - ▸ **If Touched.** Cumulative 1:12 chance one rises as **wight** (once only). Otherwise, skeleton nearly rises, but collapses into dust.
  - ▸ **Treasure.** The wight wears a gold *Scarab of Protection*.
- **Racks.** Red shield with black bull painted on it, three spears.
- **Walls.** Scorch marks and scratches. Deep, sweeping gouges at chest and head height.
- **Beastmen.** Three listen from Area 14. If PCs are noisy/destructive, adjust their attitudes one step toward **hostile**.

13. BULL STATUE

- **Bull Statue.** As Area 7. 40 gp scattered at statue's feet.

14. HIDDEN HALL

Hall: Silent and narrow. Stale, dead air. **Smell:** Urine and body odor, eye-watering. **Floor:** Scattered with rat bones and centipede husks.

- **Beastmen.** Three. Ragged, gray fur. Each stands by one of the doors, listening. They regroup in Area 14 if PCs enter. If PCs are noisy, adjust their attitude one step toward **hostile**.
  - ▸ **NPCs. Haruut** (stocky, mistrustful), **Grall** (young, timid), **Chops** (long jowls, blustery). They speak in harsh whispers and cringe at loud sounds.
- **Secret Doors.** All visible from this side.

15. JAR STORAGE

Terracotta Jars: Clustered in corners. Fat and rounded, various heights. **Air:** Sulfuric scent. **Sound:** Occasional faint squeak and hiss. **South Door:** White, jagged lines gouged into the stone.

- **Jars.** 20 jars sealed with cork and wax. Stamped with images of people carving wheat with scythes. Sticky, black mush inside.
  - ▸ **Explosive.** Shaking/striking jar causes it to shatter from sulfuric gas buildup. DC 12 DEX or 1d4 damage. Possible chain reaction.
  - ▸ **Treasure.** Cumulative 1:20 chance of finding an ivory egg shot with gray veins inside one (40 gp). It's actually a cockatrice egg.
- **South Door.** Carving in Common: "R.I.P. Orwyn the Younger."

16. OFFERING BOWLS

Halls: A weighty, stone bowl in each. Chest-high. **Murals:** Rows of peasants pour jars of gold coins and wheat into massive, gray bowls. Imperious, red-armored warriors with bronze spears supervise.

- **Stone Bowls.** Smooth and worn. Placing food or gold inside grants a Luck Token (once per character).
- **Human NPC. Giuseppe Baldini**, N herbalist (crotchety, middle-aged, poor). Wants treasure. Hides behind southeast bowl.

17. BROKEN BULL STATUE

Bull Statue: Towering (10'), bronze. Head and horns smashed deeply into cracked wall. **Body:** Pinned between wall and bull head.

- **Statue.** No longer functions. Shattered emerald (20 gp) embedded in forehead.
- **Body.** Young, human man in chainmail and helm. Carries bastard sword and shield (splintered). Dark green cloak.
  - ▸ **Backpack.** Torch, 10 pitons, 60' rope, withered apple, and a silver locket with a painting of a smiling, red-haired woman (5 gp).

18. CENTRAL COURTYARD

Bull Statue: 20' tall, black onyx, rippling muscle. Horns lowered and dotted with white objects. **Courtyard:** Sandy flagstones, sun-scorched. Heaps of bleached bones. **Red Pillars:** Free-standing, some shattered and crumbling. Cast cool, dark shadows.

- **The Scarlet Minotaur.** 3:6 chance of being present. If not, cumulative 1:6 chance per round it returns. **Minotaur:** 9' tall, wine-red fur. Charges at shadows, headbutts pillars, snorts and bellows. Two-headed, bronze *+1 greataxe* called *Bloodlust*; wielder deals x4 damage on a critical hit.
- **Bull Statue.** 30 humanoid skulls in various states of rot punched onto horns like necklace beads. Some have traces of gray fur.
  - ▸ **Ritual Sacrifice.** Punching a freshly beheaded humanoid skull onto a horn grants +1 point of Strength. **Each additional time:** cumulative 1:4 chance of transforming into a beastman.
- **Bones.** Trampled and crushed. No skulls. Piles of dented armor and broken weapons, both steel and bronze.
  - ▸ **Treasure.** Each round spent sifting reveals one of the following: **1.** Scarred mithral shield carved with prowling tiger (40 gp), **2.** Bag of 60 gp stamped with long-dead emperor, **3.** *Scroll of Burning Hands* in bronze tube adorned with jade dragons (80 gp), **4.** Silvered longsword with half-moon pommel (30 gp).

19. BAS-RELIEF HALL

Creature: Gangly, gray-furred humanoid sprawled on the ground facedown. Lumpy burlap sack near hand. **Walls:** Bas-relief carvings dense with human figures and scenes.

- **Beastman NPC. Brell** (frail, panicky). Fell and cracked his head fleeing from a sound. Wakes up in 1d4 rounds.
  - ▸ **Traits.** Scorned younger brother of beastmen leader, **Rogath** (Area 23). Naively loyal. Hopes to earn his brother's affection.
  - ▸ **Burlap Sack.** Two dead rats, necks snapped. A gift for Rogath.
- **Carvings.** Scenes of acrobats leaping over charging bulls and warriors fighting in ritualistic combat.
  - ▸ **Hidden Niche.** Behind a bull-leaper. Silver, horned helm (15 gp).

20. MOSAIC ROOM

Floor: Mosaic of rich orange, yellow, and red tiles in a swirl pattern.

- **Mosaic.** Pattern camouflages a mottled **ochre jelly**. 3:6 chance of stepping on it without careful inspection.

21. THRONE CHAMBER

Door: Bronze, emblazoned with sun and projecting rays. Locked.

- **Door.** Key is in Area 5. Each failed attempt to open without key causes door to glow hot. Cumulative 1:6 chance it shoots three random rays of fire (+4 attack, 2d6 damage each).
- **Inside.** Bronze throne with **skeleton** (not undead) impaled by a golden spear. Red **pillars** with script in ancient Common.
  - ▸ **Skeleton.** Sits on throne (50 gp, two gear slots). Wears a gold diadem with a pearl (60 gp). Hands clasped around *+1 spear* called *Vigilant*. Its wielder cannot be surprised.
  - ▸ **Pillars**. Lists of tributes paid to the Bull God, Oros, by the Warrior-Kings. **Damanthus the Brave** gave gold, **Sarpen the Wise** gave wheat, and **Minoros the Cruel** gave blood.

22. LABYRINTH

Halls: Narrow, 20' tall, shadowy at top. Tight corners. Hot wind rushes through. **Floor:** Skirls of sand blown in from outside.

- **Sand.** Fading, cloven hoofprints. Two handspans wide each.
- **Dead-Ends.** Clusters of gourd-sized, terracotta jars. Various earth tones and shapes. Most are smashed.
  - ▸ **Intact Jars.** 1d6 per dead-end. Each has 1d4 gp, handful of ash, and pinkie-sized, human doll of colorful thread. **Taking anything:** 1:20 chance of **ghost** haunting on next full moon.

23. BEASTMEN LAIR

Creatures: 15 hunched, gray-furred humanoids chewing on centipedes and speaking in harsh whispers. One lounges on a mat of rat pelts, picking his teeth. **Room:** Grimy, cramped, scattered with rodent bones. **Smell:** Unwashed bodies, urine.

- **Beastmen.** Hostile toward noise-makers. Superstitious about the (non-existent) dragons that wait outside the citadel to eat them.
  - ▸ **NPCs. Rogath** (hulking, lazy, feared leader). **Minions: Grenton** (wiry, mistrustful), **Hargol** (eyes point in different directions, agrees to everything), **Beetle** (scuttles, elaborate plan-maker).
  - ▸ **Alliance.** Rogath wants Scarlet Minotaur dead so he can be king of the citadel. Cheerfully sends his hated brother, **Brell** (Area 19), and his non-minions into danger to help this effort.
- **Secret Doors.** All visible from this side. A beastman guards each.

24. LOOKOUT ROOM

Creatures: Two shaggy, stooped humanoids listen sullenly at doors. **Room:** Filthy, low ceiling. **Stench:** Wet animal and dung.

- **NPCs. Irvog** (young, earnest), **Blort** (scarred face, disciplined). If PCs are noisy, adjust their attitude one step toward **hostile**.
- **Secret Doors.** All visible from this side.

25. TRAINING CHAMBER

Armor Stands: Five suits of red-dyed leather reinforced with bronze studs. **Weapon Rack:** Bronze weapons covered in a rime of dust. **Walls:** Countless chips and nicks.

- **Armor.** Touching armor or taking a weapon off rack causes three suits to spring to life (**animated armor**) and attack for 1d4 rounds.
- **Weapon Rack.** Five short swords, longswords, shields, and spears.

26. HALL OF KINGS

Alcoves: Bronze, lifelike statue of a man on a raised pedestal in each.

- **Statues.** Athletic, proud, similar facial features. Draped in robes, wearing diadems with pearls (40 gp each). Each holds a weapon.
  - ▸ **Inscriptions.** In ancient Common. **Damanthus**, Son of Aster (greatsword), **Sarpen**, Son of Damanthus (spear), **Minoros**, Son of Sarpen (greataxe).
  - ▸ **Diadems.** Trapped. Touching the pearl causes the statue to swing its weapon (+5 attack).

27. SACRIFICE CAVE

Cave: Chilly and damp, high ceiling (30'). Dripping stalactites. **Pool:** Crimson water, murky and still. **Smell:** Coppery, metallic tang.

- **Spirits.** Dozens of smoky, humanlike shadows flicker at the edge of darkness. If the **light** ever goes out, they descend with ghostly shrieks, dealing 1d8 damage/round to each character.
- **Pool.** 20' deep. Cursed water clouded with blood. DC 12 CON for each round of contact or temporarily lose 1 point of Wisdom (heals after rest). If 0 Wisdom, permanently become catatonic.
  - ▸ **On Bottom.** Graveyard of dozens of human and bull skeletons. Among them are 200 gp, a *Wand of Blind/Deafen*, three onyx bull statuettes (15 gp each), *Boots of the Cat*, and a tiny bottle that houses the soul of a mighty sorcerer named Malfune.

NPCs

BEASTMEN NPCS

d10	Names	Appearances	Behaviors
1	Rat / Gobbo	Patchy / Sickly	Glares / Lurks
2	Barto / Hule	Scarred / Fat	Whispers / Burps
3	Egor / Ralk	Broken jaw or nose	Scratches / Snorts
4	Dent / Borvin	Stooped / Short	Picks nose / Growls
5	Nila / Bugg	Elderly / Stout	Creeps / Rushes
6	Tail / Ludo	Missing ear or tooth	Yawns / Drools
7	Skred / Billo	Braided hair / Bald	Limps / Sulks
8	Halda / Yarv	White fur / Skinny	Paces / Chews nails
9	Crag / Dorel	Clean / Blank stare	Polite / Complains
10	Lorga / Mouse	Wild eyes / Lanky	Curses / Silent

ETTERCAP NPCS

d10	Names	Appearances	Behaviors
1	Skalt / Trisk	Groomed / Rotund	Preening / Haughty
2	Kreel / Bisky	Singed fur / Gangly	Twitches / Cowers
3	Slivin / Slaask	Blue eyes / Spotted	Bossy / Skeptical
4	Tiri / Vilis	Pained / Hunched	Delicate / Squeamish
5	Chiska / Liss	Springy / Withered	Hasty / Alarmist
6	Jarla / Miri	Sickly / Molting	Distracted / Mutters
7	Char / Squill	Missing limb / Tall	Clicks claws / Hisses
8	Fisk / Yeek	Scarred / Lumpish	Nosy / Gossips
9	Chirr / Vim	Filthy / Hulking	Critical / Sarcastic
10	Rask / Miska	Jewelry / Clothing	Rude / Surly

Minoros Respawns...

The Scarlet Minotaur (Minoros) is an immortal being of rage and violence. If he dies, his body reforms within the Lost Citadel. He returns to life at full HP.

Minoros reforms with mundane versions of any magical equipment he lost (for instance, he has an ordinary greataxe if the PCs took *Bloodlust*).

MINOROS RESPAWNS

d12	It Takes...	Location	The Minotaur...
1	1 round	Where PCs are	Gains 1 greataxe attack
2	1d4 rounds	Area 1	Gains 1d8 HP
3	1d4 rounds	Area 2	Charge deals x3 damage
4	2d8 rounds	Area 15	Is next random encounter
5	2d8 rounds	Area 16	Wears plate mail (AC 15)
6	1 day	Area 26	Gains 1d4 HP
7	1 day	Area 21	Focuses on his prior killer
8	1 day	Area 22	Loses 1d4 HP
9	1 week	Area 22	Charge reduced to near
10	1 week	Area 18	Has no armor (AC 11)
11	2 weeks	Area 18	Loses 1d8 HP
12	1 month	Pool in Area 27	Loses 1 greataxe attack

"He'll be back, just you wait. And he'll remember you."
-Argov of Reme, human fighter

Monsters

ANIMATED ARMOR

An old suit of armor magically animated by a vengeful spirit.

AC 15, **HP** 11, **ATK** 1 longsword +3 (1d8), **MV** near, **S** +3, **D** -1, **C** +2, **I** -1, **W** +1, **Ch** +0, **AL** C, **LV** 2

Statue. When standing still, looks exactly like a suit of armor.

BEASTMAN

A cave hominid with scraggly fur and a stone-tipped spear.

AC 12 (leather), **HP** 5, **ATK** 1 spear (close/near) +2 (1d6 + 1), **MV** near, **S** +2, **D** +1, **C** +1, **I** -2, **W** +1, **Ch** -1, **AL** C, **LV** 1

Brutal. +1 damage with melee weapons (included).

CAVE CREEPER

Chittering centipedes the size of horses with grasping tentacles.

AC 12, **HP** 18, **ATK** 1 bite +3 (1d6) and 1 tentacles +3 (1d8 + toxin), **MV** near (climb), **S** +2, **D** +2, **C** +0, **I** -3, **W** +1, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 4

Toxin. DC 12 CON or paralyzed 1d4 rounds.

DARKMANTLE

A floating, black octopus with rows of red eyes and a webbed skirt of tentacles.

AC 13, **HP** 4 **ATK** 1 bite +3 (1d4) or 1 darkness, **MV** near (fly), **S** -2, **D** +3, **C** +0, **I** -3, **W** +0, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 1

Darkness. Extinguish all light sources in near.

ETTERCAP

Bipedal, eight-eyed spiderfolk with spindly legs and purple fur.

AC 12, **HP** 14, **ATK** 2 bite +2 (1d6) or 1 poison web (near) +2, **MV** near (climb), **S** +0, **D** +2, **C** +1, **I** +0, **W** +0, **Ch** -1, **AL** C, **LV** 3

Poison Web. One target stuck in place and 1d4 damage/round. DC 12 DEX on turn to escape.

GHOST

A wavering spirit with a face contorted in rage or sadness.

AC 13, **HP** 27, **ATK** 2 death touch +5 (1d8 + life drain) or 1 possess, **MV** near (fly), **S** -2, **D** +3, **C** +0, **I** +0, **W** +0, **Ch** +4, **AL** C, **LV** 6

Greater Undead. Immune to morale checks. Only damaged by silver or magical sources.

Incorporeal. In place of attacks, become corporeal or incorporeal.

Life Drain. 1d4 CON damage. Death if reduced to 0 CON.

Possess. Must be corporeal. One target, close range. Contested CHA check. If ghost wins, it inhabits target's body and controls it for 2d4 rounds.

OCHRE JELLY

An orange puddle of quivering slime.

AC 9, **HP** 20, **ATK** 2 tentacle +3 (1d6), **MV** near (climb), **S** +2, **D** -1, **C** +2, **I** -4, **W** -3, **Ch** -4, **AL** N, **LV** 4

Split. If cut or chopped, split into two smaller oozes (divide remaining HP between both). Can split up to four times.

PEASANT

A commoner in worn clothes.

AC 10, **HP** 4, **ATK** 1 club +0 (1d4), **MV** near, **S** +0, **D** +0, **C** +0, **I** +0, **W** +0, **Ch** +0, **AL** L, **LV** 1

SCARLET MINOTAUR

A ferocious, scarlet-furred bull-man with hooves and curved horns. He stalks the Lost Citadel in an unending fury.

AC 14 (chainmail), **HP** 34, **ATK** 2 *Bloodlust* greataxe +7 (1d10 + 1, x4 on critical hit) and 1 horns +6 (1d12), **MV** near, **S** +4, **D** +1, **C** +3, **I** +1, **W** +2, **Ch** +1, **AL** C, **LV** 7

Charge. In place of attacks, move up to double near in a straight line and make 1 horns attack. If hit, x2 damage.

SCARAB, SWARM

A chittering cloud of iridescent, oval-shaped beetles.

AC 13, **HP** 14, **ATK** 2 bite +3 (1d6), **MV** near (fly), **S** -1, **D** +3, **C** +1, **I** -3, **W** +0, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 3

SKELETON

A bleach-boned skeleton with red pinpoints of light in its eyes.

AC 13 (chainmail), **HP** 11, **ATK** 1 shortsword +1 (1d6) or 1 shortbow (far) +0 (1d4), **MV** near, **S** +1, **D** +0, **C** +2, **I** -2, **W** +0, **Ch** -1, **AL** C, **LV** 2

Undead. Immune to morale checks.

WIGHT

A pale, armored undead warrior with sinister intelligence.

AC 14 (chainmail), **HP** 15, **ATK** 1 bastard sword +3 (1d10) and 1 life drain +3, **MV** near, **S** +3, **D** +1, **C** +2, **I** +1, **W** +0, **Ch** +3, **AL** C, **LV** 3

Greater Undead. Immune to morale checks. Only damaged by silver or magical sources.

Life Drain. 1d4 CON damage. Death if reduced to 0 CON.

Magic Items

ASTERION, GREATSWORD

A bronze, brightly polished blade as tall as a human.

Bonus. +1 greatsword.

Benefit. You cannot be moved against your will while you wield this sword.

BLOOD BOWL

A terracotta bowl engraved with a warrior drinking black rain.

Benefit. Drinking fresh blood poured into the bowl heals 1d4 HP. The bowl crumbles after this.

BLOODLUST, GREATAXE

A double-headed, bronze greataxe crusted with old blood.

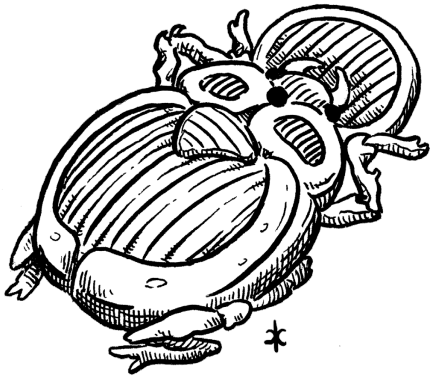
Bonus. +1 greataxe.

Benefit. You deal x4 damage on critical hits made with this weapons.

BOOTS OF THE CAT

Gray, doeskin boots as thin and soft as slippers.

Benefit. You can jump up to a near distance from a standstill. Your checks to move silently are always easy (DC 9).



SCARAB OF PROTECTION

A brooch made from a horned scarab beetle dipped in gold.

Benefit. If you die, make a DC 18 Constitution check. If you succeed, you are unconscious instead of dead.

SCROLL OF BURNING HANDS

A copper leaf scroll that is always warm to the touch.

Benefit. You can cast the *burning hands* spell with this scroll (DC 11 spellcasting check). The scroll crumbles after an attempt to cast the spell from it, successful or not.

SCROLL OF HOLD PORTAL

A tightly rolled parchment scroll scribed with symbols of locks.

Benefit. You can cast the *hold portal* spell with this scroll (DC 11 spellcasting check). The scroll crumbles after an attempt to cast the spell from it, successful or not.

VIGILANT, SPEAR

A golden, broad-bladed spear with crimson tassels.

Bonus. +1 spear.

Benefit. You can't be surprised (you always roll for initiative in surprise rounds and are not treated as unaware).

WAND OF BLIND/DEAFEN

A bone wand carved with various animals' eyes and ears.

Benefit. You can cast the *blind/deafen* spell with this wand (DC 12 spellcasting check). On a failure, you can't use this wand again until you successfully rest.

On a critical failure, the wand breaks permanently and you must roll a mishap if you are subject to them.

Mark Sons

Thus Spoke Malfune

Malfune speaks, foolish mortal!

Would you dare to ignore my wisdom, my words of old and times agone and epochs undreamed of by those of such minuscule account as yourself?

Heed not the pipsqueakulence of my voice! For though I am trapped in this accursed bottle, and thus diminutive in size, it by no means reduces the magnitude of my sagacity.

Firstly, I must pour you a small dram of my gratitude for prizing me from the red depths of that pond most inky and abhorrent and filled with bovine dung.

Secondly, I must caution you to light a new torch. Immediately. Plunge us not into darkness, you fool! Malfune's grand mind is of no use to you if you are dead!

Lastly, it is time to remove the cork from the bottle that entraps my physical corpus. No? You fear Malfune, do you?

Good. Perhaps you are not quite the fool I thought you were.

Very well. I will remain inside the confines of my prison. Alas, I will not be able to bring my magnificent sorcery to bear against your foes from in here... even the Archmage Malfune must obey the Sixth Law of Extradimensional Containment, as I'm sure you know.

I see that you maneuver for a deal, a pact of the sort that archdevils cut with only the most preeminent magicians. Very well! I am at your service. Release me, and I will grant you a boon that fate decides...

MALFUNE BOONS

d4	Malfune will...
1	Cast the *wish* spell one time on your behalf
2	Forge you one random magic item (*SD* pg. 282)
3	Teach you one random wizard spell of any tier
4	Betray you utterly

Oh No, You Died!

YOUR NEW CHARACTER IS...

d20	Details
1	Trapped inside a cocoon of ettercap webs in a dark corner
2	Hanging by your backpack from a spur in the stone wall
3	Waking up on the floor with no memory of the past week
4	Hiding inside a large clay jar painted with leaping bulls
5	Standing very still in the next room to look like a statue
6	Materializing here after some unexpected magical mishap
7	Sleeping under a pile of dusty, moth-eaten rags and trash
8	A prisoner of the ettercaps; you just escaped from them
9	A lost traveler who thought this was a safe place to camp
10	Looking for your cousin, Giuseppe Baldini (see Area 16)
11	The last surviving member of a party the Minotaur just killed
12	A prisoner of the beastmen; you just broke free of them
13	A secret bull god cultist who wants Oros worship to return
14	Actively being chased by another random encounter
15	Hog tied and gagged with a note that says "Minotaur bait"
16	Stuck to the ceiling by a cave creeper that will be back later
17	A descendant of Orwyn the Younger (see Areas 15 and 17)
18	Wrapped in an ancient, dusty carpet set against the wall
19	Crammed inside a large treasure chest in the next room
20	Thrown through a dimensional door to land here in a heap

"I can't shake the feeling that I've met you all before..."
-Norla Grackle, newly recruited wizard

Mark Lyons
2026